

when compared to his overall average of 30.37 in First-Class cricket.

Prasidh, on the other hand, can be a handful with the old ball with his height and ability to hit the deck hard. Though he is largely untested with the new ball, Prasidh's tearaway pace and scorching run in the recently concluded Indian Premier League could tip the scales in his favour. However, Prasidh's inclusion in the playing XI could force Siraj to operate largely with the new ball, which isn't his strongest suit.

Thus, while making its choice for the third seamer, India will have to make a trade-off between new-ball expertise and old-ball prowess — Arshdeep or Prasidh. Meanwhile, Akash could get a look-in when Bumrah doesn't play. In an ideal world, India would have wanted a well-rounded four-man pace attack to lead the charge, but its undercooked batting unit warrants the insurance of a seam-bowling all-rounder.

Shardul Thakur had a taste of English conditions during the tour in 2021, but Nitish Kumar Reddy appears to be the frontrunner, especially with bowling coach Morne Morkel admitting he wants to see the 22-year-old bowl more often in Tests.

Similarly, the selection of the lone spinner in the XI will be hostage to the extent of batting depth the team requires. Only one of Ravindra Jadeja and Washington Sundar is a likely starter, with the possibility of slotting in specialist spinner Kuldeep Yadav only arising in favourable conditions, such as those prevalent at The Oval.



Despite a lack of experience, pedigree, and Bumrah's limited availability, the Indian bowling attack has a golden opportunity to eclipse its counterpart.

The legendary duo of James Anderson and Stuart Broad has walked into the sunset, and a spearhead isn't on the horizon. Mark Wood, Jofra Archer and Gus Atkinson are battling injuries; Chris Woakes is on the mend, and a host of up-and-coming quicks are also

Spin dilemma: India is likely to pick just one between Ravindra Jadeja and Washington Sundar, with Kuldeep Yadav an option only if conditions, like those at The Oval, favour spin.

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contending with fitness issues.

In 2007 — the last time India won a Test series in England and much before the country showed signs of ushering in a pace-bowling renaissance — the trio of Zaheer Khan, R. P. Singh and S. Sreesanth, with some help from Sourav Ganguly's dabbly-dobblies and the inimitable Anil Kumble, outshone the hosts.

The crop that followed, comprising Ishant Sharma, Umesh Yadav and Shami, raised the pace quotient a notch up, but a win in England remained elusive for over a decade.

Now, with a generational genius in Bumrah showing the way, India's white-ball exponents will want their moment in the sun with the red cherry and to snap an 18-year wait.

Indian bowlers in last two Test series in England (sorted by bowling average)

Bowler	M	Wkts	Ave.	S/R	E/R
Hanuma Vihari	2	3	12.66	21.0	3.61
Umesh Yadav	2	9	23.55	40.8	3.45
Jasprit Bumrah	8	37	23.78	51.9	2.74
Hardik Pandya	4	10	24.70	38.5	3.84
Ishant Sharma	7	23	26.56	54.0	2.95
R. Ashwin	4	11	32.72	76.1	2.57
Mohd. Siraj	5	18	33.00	51.1	3.87
Shardul Thakur	3	8	33.37	50.2	3.98
Mohd. Shami	9	29	36.79	63.4	3.48
Ravindra Jadeja	6	13	45.76	101.8	2.69
Kuldeep Yadav	1	0	—	—	4.88